



SI STEP into Istanbul's Basilica Cistern, the first thing that comes to mind is Dan Brown's

Inferno. Walking through the dimly lit underground chamber surrounded with rows of ancient columns, soft lights reflecting off the water and Medusa's famous stone heads lurking beneath the columns, I can't help but recall the novel's climactic scenes, half-expecting Robert Langdon to emerge around a corner. Later, standing beneath the vast dome of Hagia Sophia, I find myself again thinking of Brown's descriptions and the sense of history layered upon history that defines Istanbul. Yet no novel, however vivid, can fully capture the experience of being there in person.

Istanbul is not merely a city. It is a crossroads of civilisations and few places on earth can claim a history as rich or as consequential. Founded as Byzantium, transformed into Constantinople by the Roman Emperor Constantine, and later becoming the capital of the Ottoman Empire, Istanbul has served as the centre of power for centuries. Little wonder, this is a city where history never feels distant. Today, home to more than 16 million people, it rises across the seven hills overlooking the Bosphorus Strait—the narrow waterway that separates Europe from Asia. Being the only city in the world that spans two continents, its unique geography has shaped its identity for centuries. The city feels simultaneously European and Asian, Christian and Islamic, ancient and modern—truly a bridge



| 87

between the East and the West.

The heart of this history lies in the Fatih district, where many of Istanbul's most famous landmarks stand within walking distance of one another. The Hagia Sophia is perhaps the most impressive. Built in the sixth century as a cathedral before being transformed into a mosque after the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople, it embodies the city's layered history. Christian mosaics coexist alongside Islamic calligraphy. Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, the first president of Türkiye, converted it into a museum in 1934 to project the secular ideals of the newly formed Turkish Republic. However, since 2020, it has reverted to being a functional mosque. It is currently under restoration and visitors are allowed only in the upper galleries. To understand more about the Hagia Sophia, visit the Hagia Sophia History and

▲ Aerial view of the Hagia Sophia

Experience Museum (tickets start from 35 euros) that brings the past to life through light and sound.

Directly across from Hagia Sophia stands the Blue Mosque, officially known as the Sultan Ahmed Mosque. Its elegant domes and six towering minarets dominate the skyline. Inside, thousands of intricate blue Iznik tiles give the mosque its popular name. Entry is free here.

Nearby, is the Topkapi Palace (tickets from 60 euros) that reveals the grandeur of the Ottoman Empire. For centuries, it served as the residence of the sultans who ruled vast territories stretching across Europe, Asia, and Africa. Wandering through its courtyards,



◀ Aerial view of the Blue Mosque, officially known as the Sultan Ahmed Mosque